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We have been reporting on the Sangh Parivar from which the BJP was born almost since the start of the magazine. Our first cover story in March 1978 was on the RSS, titled 'Waiting for Direction', when it was starting to make its presence felt. Our coverage of the BJP started on its official birthday on March 6, 1980 when the Janata Party split on the issue of dual membership. Our cover headlines for the BJP make interesting reading as it has had its full measure of crises, triumphs, defeats, leadership battles and internal wrangling. We have done 46 cover stories on the BJP and here are some of the key headlines which tell us their story: 'In the Wilderness' in 1985 following Rajiv Gandhi's massive mandate, 'The Blossoming of L.K. Advani' in 1990 when he set off on his famous yatra, 'Hindu Divided Family' in 1991 over the differences in the Parivar, 'BJP's Changing Colours' in 1998 when the party under A.B. Vajpayee adopted a softer avatar, 'Sulking Saffron' in 2000 when the party was riven with dissent and personality clashes, 'The Party is Over' in 2002 after the BJP's demoralising defeats in assembly elections, 'Paralysed' in 2004 after its loss in the General Elections and 'The A-bomb' in 2005 after Advani's Jinnah controversy.

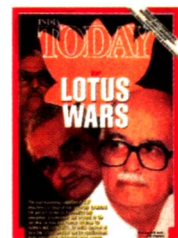
Following the BJP's worst performance in 20 years in the recent Lok Sabha elections, it faces an open revolt by its senior leaders against its current leadership. This has undermined its political stature as the national alternative to the Congress. At one level, the crisis is to do with the confusion over ideology and whether Hindutva has any future in the light of new ground realities. From its peak of electoral popularity in 1999 when Vajpayee was its liberal face till 2009 has seen an erosion of the number of assembly seats and percentage of vote-share in its traditional strongholds. At another level, the crisis is about the clash between the Old Guard and the New. The older leaders are angry that recent appointments amount to rewarding failure and sidelining those with an established reputation and standing. It is clear that their target is also Advani, the cause of much of the current schism. He is at the fag-end of his political career and the erosion of his authority, along with that of Rajnath Singh, suggests that the revolt in the party could gather steam if corrective measures are not taken.

Our cover story this week takes a critical look at the ballooning crisis in the party and what it means for its future. Editor Prabhu Chawla analyses the roots of the present crisis and the inner conflict between the factions. He examines what it portends for the party which always claimed to be the party with a difference. As Chawla says: "The BJP is now a party without a slogan, without a leader and without an ideology."

The recent General Elections which gave one party a clear mandate was the best chance for the revival of the two-party system which has served India so well in the past. Good opposition is important for the health of our democracy. It's a pity that the BJP has messed this up for now.

Aroon Purie

(Aroon Purie)



(FROM TOP) OUR
APRIL 2002, OCT
1995 AND MARCH
1990 COVERS